

Science is the new god...

...technology the prophet, computers our idols, and algorithms our corrupt clergy.



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“Question everything rather than accept statements – whether they come from governments, religions or even with a tag of science”

Like an omnipotent, all-knowing God, science and technology is also ever-present today. It determines all that we do – from simple choices such as which books to read and which route to take, to more important aspects such as which news updates to read (whose importance is decided by EdgeRank algorithms on FB) or which information to believe (with the search giant quietly deciding which information it will let you access).

It's really all dictated by technology and more specifically, controlled by algorithms. By itself, not all of this is subversive. But it is a part of a much larger trend – the deification of science/technology, which has crossed over into blind faith. If there is even a semblance of scientific methodology to any idea or theory, it must be true. An algorithm churned it out? It must be true, and so on...

Think of the constructs on which these algorithms run – the humble bits of data. Today, we refer to them collectively as “Big Data”. Grandiose and pompous as it sounds (like *High Priest* or *Sanctum Sanctorum*), it's probably justified that we've elevated data to such a lofty status. Collected data, when put through the algorithmic cauldron, can reveal disturbing patterns and even secret details about people, which can ultimately decide their fates (think background checks by prospective employers).

The same mysticism that shrouded religion has now permeated into technology. Complex or fantastical tasks are often explained by the shorthand of “it's the algorithm at work”. Sometimes, these new gods are our convenient scapegoats as well. You may have seen this when interacting with customer service executives, who can't help you because “the system isn't allowing it”. This is very akin to what Aamir Khan described as “wrong number” in his recent film P.K. What's disheartening is that many of us readily buy it as a perfectly valid reason. This mythical “system” is nothing short of a computer deity then. Something you can't reason with and works in mysterious ways. If an answer is attributed to a computational or (seemingly) scientific process, it's regarded as the gospel truth.

Will the day soon arrive then when we arrest people or even execute them... all because, well, an algorithm told us to? It sounds frightening, but implausible right? Like the witch trials must have seemed to people in the early 1600s or the inquisition seemed to the Mayans. Or how a Minority Report-like situation seems to us?

Another disturbing trend: Slap on the tag of “The science of xyz” and people will swallow just about anything, from circumcision to the curative properties of magnets. There's a lot of pseudoscience floating around. Just look at what happened at the Indian Science Congress (page 114) and you'll need no more convincing.

And what about the fanaticism? The next time you are privy to an on-going God vs. Science debate, simply replace the word “science” with “God”. You'd have a perfect example of a tirade delivered by two zealots – one religious and the other a so-called “rationalist” – you would be surprised to find that the religious radical would be indistinguishable from the science nut.

The aim of my tirade, on the other hand, is to shake you out of your stupor, if you have fallen into one. As Digit readers, you already have questioning minds and this is just fodder. Question everything rather than accept statements – whether they come from governments, religions or even with a tag of science.

To be able to question everything, however, you need to live in an environment that allows you to challenge status quo; if somebody is taking that away from you, fight back to re-create that environment. In our country, censorship has already reached ridiculously mind-numbing levels. This editorial, though not controversial per se, has the potential to ruffle some feathers as well (as I hope it does). It has all the ingredients: government and religion bashing for starters. In a censorship driven society, this editorial would have probably looked like this:

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The good thing is that if the powers that be had done that to my editorial, I could've given you a pastebin link or you could've looked for the uncensored version online and you would've found it. That's possible today, so we take it for granted – but it may not last long if we do. So Digit folk, value your freedom, fight to retain it and respect the freedom of others. As for the rest, just stop getting offended at the drop of a hat...lighten up...and if you can't, bring it on...we are ready! 🔪

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Siddharth'.